

After your sinus procedure

SINUS LIFT · OAC REPAIR · SINUS INVOLVEMENT

Keep this guide handy
Call our office with any questions

Your procedure today involved the maxillary sinus — the hollow air space in your upper jaw. A thin membrane separates your mouth from this space, and we either lifted it to make room for a bone graft, or repaired an opening into it. For the next 2–3 weeks, the most important thing you can do is avoid any pressure changes that could push on the healing site. These "sinus precautions" are the core of your recovery.

TODAY	DAYS 1–7	WEEKS 2–3	MONTHS 3–6
Rest. Ice. Soft, cool foods. Head elevated. Start your medications.	Swelling peaks at 48–72h then improves. Full sinus precautions.	Continue precautions. Soreness mostly gone. Check-in visit.	Graft integrates into bone. Ready for implant (if not already placed).

Sinus precautions

FOR THE NEXT 2–3 WEEKS

- ✗ **No nose blowing.** Dab with a tissue instead.
- ✗ **No sneeze with your mouth open.** Don't pinch it off.
- ✗ **No straws.** Drink from a cup or spoon.
- ✗ **No smoking or vaping.** This matters more than anywhere else in your body.
- ✗ **No air travel.** Cabin pressure changes can disrupt the site.
- ✗ **No scuba diving or snorkeling.** Same pressure concern.
- ✗ **No heavy lifting or straining.** Anything that makes you bear down.
- ✗ **No blowing up balloons** or playing wind instruments.
- ✗ **Don't bend over** with your head below your heart.

i Why these rules? The membrane separating your mouth from your sinus is about as thin as wet tissue paper. Any action that creates pressure in your nose or sinuses — blowing, sneezing, lifting — can push against the healing site and disrupt the graft or repair. Following these rules is the single biggest thing you control.

1 The first 24 hours

- **Keep your head elevated** — use an extra pillow when sleeping. Don't lie flat for the first night.
- **Ice** 20 minutes on / 20 minutes off over the cheek. Swelling peaks at 48–72 hours.
- **No rinsing, swishing, or spitting** for 24 hours. Let saliva drain.
- Some bleeding from the *nose* on the same side is possible and normal for the first day.
- You may feel fullness or pressure in your cheek — this is normal.

2 Medications

Sinus procedures usually involve an antibiotic and a decongestant in addition to your normal pain medications. Take everything as prescribed. See your **Medication Guide** for exact dosing.

MEDICATION	WHY YOU'RE TAKING IT
Antibiotic	Prevents infection in the sinus. Take until the full course is finished, even if you feel fine.
Decongestant	Reduces swelling inside the sinus so it drains normally. Pseudoephedrine (Sudafed) is typical; take for 5–7 days.
Saline nasal spray	Keeps the nasal passages moist and gently clears debris. Safe to use 3–4× daily.
Ibuprofen + acetaminophen	First-line for pain and swelling. See Medication Guide for dosing.

⚠ **Do not use Afrin or similar nasal sprays for more than 3 days.** These work quickly but cause rebound congestion if used longer. Saline spray is safe to use as often as you want.

3 Diet & activity

GOOD CHOICES

- ✓ Yogurt, cottage cheese, pudding
- ✓ Smoothies (spoon — no straw)
- ✓ Mashed potatoes, applesauce
- ✓ Scrambled eggs, soft pasta
- ✓ Lukewarm soup from a cup

AVOID

- ✗ Straws of any kind
- ✗ Hard, crunchy, chewy foods near the site
- ✗ Very hot foods and drinks
- ✗ Carbonated drinks (the bubbles create pressure)
- ✗ Alcohol for at least 72 hours

Take it easy for **a full week**. No exercise, heavy lifting, or strenuous activity — anything that makes you grunt, strain, or bear down creates pressure in the sinus.

4 What's normal vs. what's not

NORMAL (EXPECTED)

- ✓ Mild nosebleed from the surgical side, especially day 1
- ✓ Pink-tinged nasal drainage for a few days
- ✓ Fullness or pressure in the cheek
- ✓ Swelling peaking at 48–72h, then improving
- ✓ Mild bruising of cheek or under the eye
- ✓ Slight bad taste or smell for a few days
- ✓ Sutures visible in the mouth (dissolve over 1–2 weeks)

CALL OUR OFFICE

- ✗ Heavy bleeding from the nose that won't stop after 30 min of gentle pressure
- ✗ Feeling air moving through your mouth when you breathe through your nose
- ✗ Liquid coming out of your nose when you drink
- ✗ One-sided nasal congestion or drainage that's getting worse after day 5
- ✗ Pain, swelling, or a bad taste that returns after you'd started to feel better
- ✗ Fever over 101°F
- ✗ Thick, foul-smelling yellow or green nasal discharge

i About complications. The thin membrane we work with tears in roughly **1 out of every 4 sinus lifts** — this is one of the most common events in this surgery and, when properly repaired during the procedure, does *not* affect long-term success. The mouth and sinus aren't sterile the way skin is. Even with sterile instruments and careful technique, some patients develop infection. If you notice the warning signs on the right, call us early — sinus issues are easier to treat before they become chronic.

IF WE REPAIRED AN OPENING BETWEEN YOUR MOUTH AND SINUS

Oroantral repair — a little extra care

Sometimes a tooth root sits so close to the sinus floor that removing it leaves a small opening. We closed it today, but the tissue there is under more stress than a routine graft. **Stick to the sinus precautions strictly for the full 3 weeks.** If the opening re-opens, you'll feel air moving into your mouth when you breathe, or liquid coming out of your nose when you drink. Call us right away if this happens — early recognition makes repair much easier.

5 Other things that may help

- **Sleep with your head elevated** for the first 3–5 nights. Reduces pressure and swelling.
- **No nicotine** in any form. Nicotine is especially bad here — it constricts blood vessels in the sinus lining and dramatically raises the risk of graft failure.
- **Protein and hydration.** Bone grafts heal better with adequate nutrition.
- **Bromelain** (500 mg, 3× daily, 5–7 days) — may help reduce swelling. Skip if on blood thinners or with pineapple allergy.
- **A warm (not hot) shower** can help loosen congestion without creating the pressure that blowing your nose would.

When to call us

- Air moves through your mouth when you breathe through your nose
- Liquid comes out of your nose when you drink or rinse
- Heavy nose bleeding that won't stop after 30 min of gentle pressure
- One-sided congestion or nasal drainage getting worse after day 5
- Pain, swelling, or bad taste returning after you'd started to feel better
- Thick, foul-smelling yellow or green nasal discharge
- Fever over 101°F

URGENT — DON'T WAIT

- Difficulty breathing or swallowing
- Rapidly spreading swelling to your neck or around your eye
- Vision changes

Call our office right away for the on-call provider. If you truly cannot breathe or swallow, call 911.

Sinus procedures have a longer recovery window than a typical extraction, but if you follow the precautions the outcomes are excellent. When in doubt — especially about whether you can fly, lift, or dive — call and ask before you do it.